M365-06 · Mass Communication & Broadcast Email Approval

Who may email an entire population at the organization, how they ask, and what IT will not build to help them avoid asking.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-06
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 4 — IT Management approves; Tier 2 executes.
Review cycle	Annually.

1. Purpose

Email to an entire population is the organization's loudest channel and its most easily devalued one. Every unnecessary all-staff message makes the next necessary one slightly less likely to be read, and there is no way to get that attention back.

This document says who may send to whom, how they ask, and — usefully for IT — what IT will not build for people trying to route around asking.

2. What counts as mass communication

- Any message to a whole population group: all employees, all staff, everyone at one site.
- Any message to more than roughly 200 people who did not opt in.
- Any message where recipients cannot reasonably identify why they received it. Not in scope: a departmental list people belong to by function, a Team or site where membership is the point, or a message to a cohort a department already legitimately owns.

3. Who may send to which population

Population	May be addressed by	Approval
All employees	The executive office, HR, Finance, Facilities/Security, IT, and Communications.	Tier 4 for IT-originated; the sending office's head otherwise.
A defined group (e.g. everyone at one site)	The department that owns that cohort's relationship with the organization.	That department's head.

Population	May be addressed by	Approval
Everybody at once	The executive office, Facilities/Security for emergencies, IT for service-affecting matters.	Explicit, named approval every time.
Anybody else	Not directly. Ask the office above that owns the population.	—

The list is deliberately short. Where a department has a legitimate recurring need not covered here, the answer is to add them to this document rather than to grant an exception — that way the next person can see the rule.

4. Requesting it

1. Request through the service desk, with the Appendix A fields, at least two business days ahead where it is not urgent.
2. Tier 2 checks the sender is entitled under §3, and that the population requested is the smallest that serves the purpose. “All staff” when the matter concerns one group is the commonest over-reach and is worth pushing back on gently.
3. Check whether a broadcast is the right channel at all. A portal announcement, a Teams post in an existing channel, or a note in an existing regular newsletter frequently serves better and costs the organization less attention.
4. Tier 4 approves anything addressing a whole population.
5. Send through the approved mechanism — the dynamic group (M365-04) with moderation, or the organization’s communications platform where one is in use.
6. Record it.

5. What a broadcast message must contain

- A subject line that says what it is about, not what department sent it.
- The point, in the first two sentences. People decide whether to keep reading there.
- What the recipient needs to do, if anything, and by when. Or an explicit statement that no action is needed — that sentence saves hundreds of people a moment of uncertainty.
- Who to contact, by name or by service address.
- Why they received it, where that is not obvious.
- For IT messages: no links asking for sign-in, and no requests for credentials. This is a hard rule (§8).

6. What IT will not do

IT will not	Because
Build a distribution list whose purpose is to let somebody address a population they are not entitled to address.	That is not a technical request; it is an attempt to route around §3, and it puts IT in the middle of somebody else’s governance question.

IT will not	Because
Provide an export of a population's email addresses for sending from elsewhere.	It creates an uncontrolled copy that ages immediately, and it removes every control in this document.
Send on a department's behalf to avoid the approval in §3.	IT is not a workaround.
Build a cohort group for something the system of record does not hold.	M365-04 §8. There is nothing to derive membership from.
Enable unmoderated sending to a whole-population group.	One misdirected reply-all to the whole organization is a genuinely bad afternoon for everybody.

Where IT declines, it says which office can help and offers the alternative that does work. Declining without an alternative teaches departments to route around IT, which is how shadow mailing lists start.

7. Emergency communication

- Emergency messaging — Facilities, Security, closure notices — is out of scope of the approval process here and follows the organization's emergency plan. Nothing in this document should ever delay a safety message.
- IT's role in an emergency is to make the mechanism work, not to approve the content.
- Where IT itself must broadcast urgently — a major outage, a live phishing campaign — Tier 4 approves and it goes immediately. Record it afterwards (GOV-03 §7).

8. Why this is a security control too

> **Predictable organization mail is what makes phishing detectable.**
>
> When the community knows what a legitimate organization broadcast looks like — which offices send them, what they ask for, and that they never request credentials — an imitation stands out.
>
> When broadcasts arrive unpredictably from varying senders with varying formats, everything looks plausible. Credential-harvesting messages work by looking like routine organization correspondence.
>
> So §5's formatting rules and §3's short sender list are not tidiness. They are the baseline against which the community can recognise something wrong.

9. Service levels

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Broadcast, approved, two days' notice	Sent on the requested date.
Broadcast, under two days	P3 — best effort, and the pattern recorded.
Urgent service-affecting IT message	P1 — immediately, Tier 4 approval concurrent.
Emergency safety message	Immediately. Nothing here applies.

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Request from somebody not entitled under §3	Redirected same day to the office that can help.

10. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Request, approval, population, date sent	Ticket	3 years
The message as sent	IT communications record	3 years
Declined requests and the alternative offered	Ticket	3 years
Broadcast volume by month and population	GOV-06 monthly pack	3 years

11. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
M365-04	Distribution List & Dynamic Group Standard	The population groups this uses, and §8 of that document.
M365-22	Phishing Reporting & Email Threat Response	§8, and the community notice format.
M365-05	Email Alias & Address Change Standard	Institutional sending addresses.
M365-02	Exchange Online Mailbox Standard	Sending limits and moderation.
GOV-03	Security Incident Response	Urgent IT communication.
GOV-05	Knowledge Base Article Standard	Where a portal announcement is the better channel.
Emergency plan	Your organization's emergency plan	Governs §7.

Appendix A — Request card

Field	
Who is sending	The office, and the person approving it (§3).
Which population	The smallest that serves the purpose.
Why this population	One sentence. Catches the “all staff” over-reach.
When it needs to go	Two business days’ notice where not urgent.
Has a smaller channel been considered?	A portal announcement or an existing newsletter is often better.
Action required of recipients?	Or an explicit “no action needed”.
Contact for questions	A name or a service address.

Field	
Does it contain any sign-in link?	For IT messages this must be no (§5, §8).

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.